

GE261004 DESIGN THINKING

Unit II – Empathy and Problem Definition · Presentation 3 of 6

Observation Techniques

What people cannot tell you · how involved the observer should be · AEIOU in the field · recording what you see · ethics on site

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In this presentation

- What people cannot tell you
- How involved should you be?
- Three practical methods
- The AEIOU framework
- AEIOU: what to look for
- Recording what you see
- Ethics in the field
- In class: twenty minutes out there

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Why observe at all

The part of the story an interview will never give you

What people cannot tell you

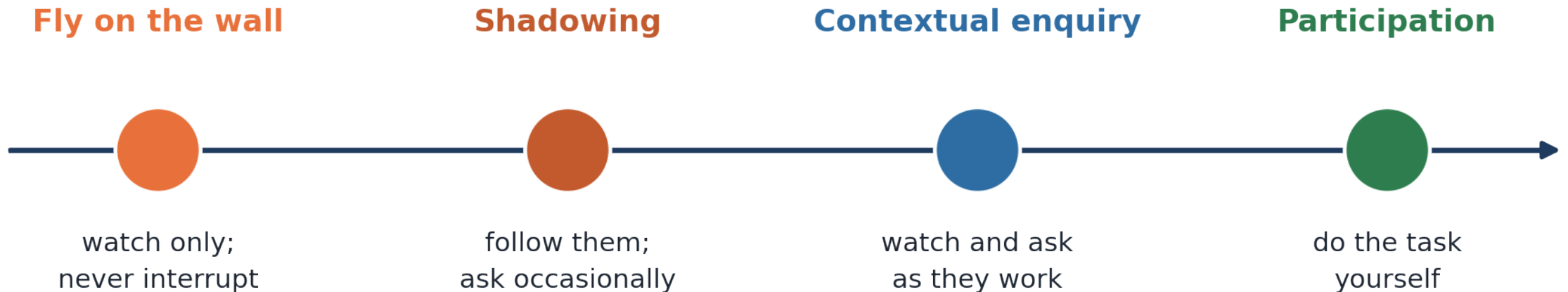
- Habits they no longer notice – the step they skip, the tool they always reach for
- Workarounds so normal to them that they never come up in conversation
- The physical setting: noise, heat, light, clutter, interruption
- How long things really take, as against how long they feel

KEY POINT An interview gives you the story people tell. Observation gives you the one they live.

How involved should you be?

LESS INVOLVED

MORE INVOLVED



the more you take part, the more you understand — and the more you change what you came to see

Four positions on one scale – pick the one the setting allows.

Three practical methods

Fly on the wall

Sit still and watch.
Best for public places
and for a first visit,
when you do not yet
know what matters.

Shadowing

Follow one person
through a whole task
or a whole shift, asking
only between steps.

Contextual enquiry

Watch them work and
ask about what they
are doing while they
are doing it.

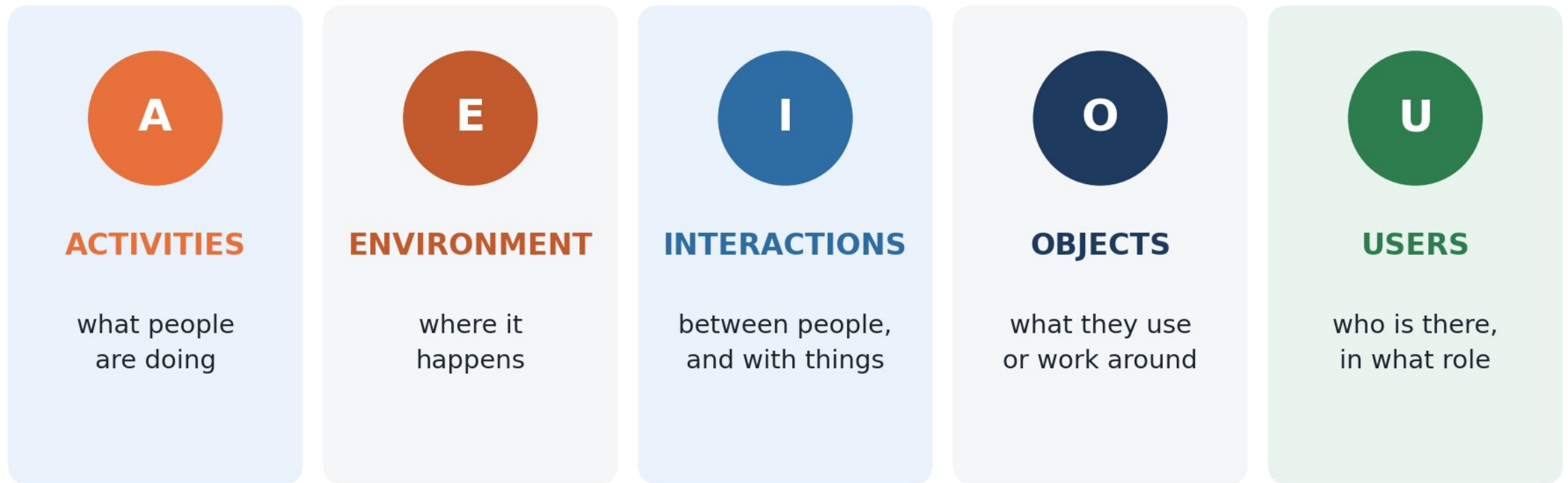
KEY POINT Your presence always changes the scene. Stay long enough for people to stop noticing you.

2

AEIOU and the field record

A framework that stops you seeing only what you expected

The AEIOU framework



Five headings that between them catch almost everything worth noting.

AEIOU: what to look for

	Look for	Example in a college canteen
Activities	Goal-directed sequences	Queuing, paying, hunting for a seat
Environment	The space and its character	Noise, crowding, where the fans are
Interactions	Person to person, person to thing	Shouting an order across a counter
Objects	What is used, made or worked around	Trays, tokens, a chair used as a table
Users	Who is present, and in what role	Staff, students, a visiting parent

Recording what you see

- Two columns, always: what you observed, and what you think it means
- Capture quotations word for word; a paraphrase destroys the evidence
- Photograph the setting and the objects, not faces, unless you asked first
- Write up within the hour – memory decays fast, and the detail is the whole value

KEY POINT “She put the tray down twice” is an observation. “She was frustrated” is an interpretation. Keep them apart.

Ethics in the field

- Say who you are, what you are doing and what the notes are for
- Anyone may decline at any moment, without giving a reason
- Never photograph or record a person without asking first
- Take extra care with children, patients, and anyone dependent on the service
- Store notes without names; share findings, never identities

KEY POINT Consent is not a form you collect once at the door. It continues through the whole visit.

In class: twenty minutes in the field

- Pick one place on campus where people wait – canteen, office counter, bus stop
- Work in pairs: two observers, two columns, twenty minutes, no interviewing
- Record against AEIOU, and count every workaround you see
- Come back and compare – what did your partner see that you did not?

ACTIVITY Go in pairs and do not speak to anyone. Bring back fifteen observations and three photographs of objects.

THINK ABOUT IT

You watched for twenty minutes. What did you see that nobody in that place would have told you?

- Which workaround had everyone stopped noticing?
- What did the physical space force people to do?
- Where did you write an interpretation and call it an observation?
- What would you go back and watch for next time?

Summary

- Observation catches habits, workarounds, setting and real durations
- Involvement runs from fly-on-the-wall to full participation
- Fly on the wall, shadowing and contextual enquiry suit different settings
- AEIOU keeps you from noticing only what you expected
- Separate observation from interpretation in two columns
- Consent is continuous, and names never leave your notebook

Next: Interviews and need finding

- Why interviews go wrong, and how to stop it
- The interview funnel and the interview guide
- Laddering and the five whys
- Stated, observed and latent needs